

The Sponsor

Matthew Baker

The Sponsor

Less than a month before our wedding, our headline sponsor goes out of business, and just like that the money disappears. Jenna gets the call. Ty and me are sitting on the futon in tank tops and khaki shorts, gawking at photos of the new weight room at Gillette Stadium™, where he works as a trainer for the Patriots®; the sunrise is still tinting the sky, bluebirds are chirping happily in the trees, and then suddenly she bursts into the apartment with the news. Jenna, Jenna, dear sweet fragile Jenna, with her bright eyes and her snub nose and her chipped nail polish, standing hardly taller than a snow shovel, wearing yoga pants and a sports bra with her hair pulled into a ponytail and her mascara smeared from crying. The ad department left her a voicemail while she was in spin class. A recording spoken by a robot. The corporation is bankrupt. The sponsorship is canceled. Her voice cracks as she explains. “I tried calling back, but nobody’s even there,” Jenna says, gesturing helplessly. In an instant, the budget for our wedding has been slashed in half. I try to sound optimistic. “Maybe we could just, like, scale back,” I say. Jenna trembles. Verge of weeping. About to snap. “Brock, this is supposed to be the most important day of our *lives*,” Jenna says, her voice squeaking. Ty wipes his mouth, sets a McMuffin™ in a wrapper down onto the table next to a cup of Folgers® on a coaster, and then says, “Realistically, you’ll probably spend the rest of your lives trying to forget the wedding ever even happened. I mean, name a single wedding you’ve been to where the couple wasn’t divorced

within three years.” Jenna is stunned. Her cheeks flush like she’s just been slapped. She looks at me, then points at Ty. “This is your best man? *This? This?*” I’m like, “Ty, bro, get out.” Ty leaves, but I wouldn’t dare embark on a quest this desperate alone, so I secretly send him a message to wait for me, and then after consoling Jenna, vowing to her that I will save the wedding, swearing to her that I will find another sponsor, and kissing her goodbye, passionately, I meet him down on the street.

“I was just trying to keep the situation in perspective,” Ty says, leaning against a parking meter with a squint.

“We’re not like that.”

“I know.”

“It’s the real thing.”

“So true.”

“Fuck, man, if we don’t find a new sponsor, the wedding is going to be ruined,” I say, starting to panic.

Ty takes me by the shoulders. I’m tall. He’s taller. He looks me in the eyes. “Brock. I’m here for you. This is why you have a best man. Seriously. I’m going to help you save the day. Let’s make some calls.”

We sit on the hood of a station wagon sponsored by Walmart®, flip-flops flat on the pavement, dialing numbers shoulder to shoulder, just like we used to do when we lived next door to each other as kids, when we’d call around the neighborhood to recruit friends for a sleepover or a game of catch. The situation is grim. Jenna and me applied for and received all of the usual sponsors for decorations and regalia, but replacing any of those would have been simple compared to trying to replace the headline sponsor. With less than a month until the wedding, we don’t have time to go through the proper application process. Ty and me are forced to call the corporations directly, angling to land an inter-

view on the spot. We stick with companies headquartered in town, hoping the ad departments will take pity on a local couple. We switch to professional voices. We turn on the charm. Most of the receptionists hang up on me without even bothering to say no. Ty isn't having any luck either, cursing every time he gets rejected.

I've just about run out of ideas of companies to try when he hangs up with a whoop.

"I got us an interview at BJ's!"

"What the fuck is that?"

"You know, like Costco, or Sam's. Just worse."

I grimace.

"What?" Ty says.

"I just wish the name was different."

"Brock. You're not going to find another sponsor with this much cash. Honestly, bro, you're not going to find another sponsor period. I haven't even come close with the other calls. This is the play."

I imagine the name of the company on a banner at the ceremony, cringing, but then remember that a minute ago we didn't have an interview anywhere. The quest had seemed impossible. The wedding had seemed doomed. But we can do this. We still have a chance.

I offer him a fist-bump with a grin.

"I can't believe you got us an interview with less than a month to go," I say.

"Must be desperate, who knows, but the interview's in an hour, so let's hit the road," Ty says.

I dig through pockets, taking out keys with a jingle. Ty glances at his coupe, which is sponsored by Nike®, then looks at my pickup, which is sponsored by Denny's®. "We can't show up in that," Ty says. "No offense. I'll drive."

I grab the fluorescent binder with the wedding paperwork from the glovebox in my

pickup, Ty stomps the clutch and punches the brake and hits the ignition in his coupe, and we drive through the city, Ray-Bans® on. We were supposed to work out at the gym today. We've got a tub of creatine riding in the backseat. I stare into the wing mirror, at my stubble and my neck and my shoulders and my arms and the road stretching behind the car in a blur of dark bricks and gray stones. Colorful kites are flying above the John Deere® Boston Common. Tour guides in colonial costumes march along the Freedom Trail, presented by Twinings™. I love having ripped muscles, the sensation of tight abs straining against the shifting momentum as the car takes a turn, the feeling of pecs too firm to bounce as the car rolls over a speed bump, of tensing a rigid bicep, of flexing a hard tricep, of quads and calves that—

“We're here, bro,” Ty says, shifting into park.

BJ's® has a black leather sofa in the reception area of the ad department.

“Let me do the talking,” I whisper.

“Just don't make any blowjob jokes,” Ty whispers.

“I'm not an idiot,” I whisper.

“But seriously though,” Ty whispers.

An assistant leads us into a boardroom to meet with a pair of ad execs named Paige and Kayla, who both wear charcoal suits and horn-rimmed glasses. We sit when we're invited. Oxfords clacking on the floor, the assistant takes the fluorescent binder from me, walks along the conference table, past all the empty chairs, to hand the wedding paperwork to Paige and Kayla, and then leaves the boardroom. Sunlight shimmers on the glass walls.

“So you're interested in BJ's.”

“Um, the company, yeah.”

Paige and Kayla flip through the paperwork in the binder.

“Tell us about the wedding.”

I swell with pride on reflex. “Jenna, my girlfriend, or fiancée technically, she has a vision, she has an eye, she’s been planning this since she was in kindergarten, and—”

“What’s she do?”

“Nurse practitioner.”

“How about you?”

“Concrete finisher.”

“Guest list?”

“Uh, four hundred and twenty-one.”

“That’s it?”

“We’ve also got some great-grandparents who’re going to stream the wedding from their nursing homes.”

“We don’t care about senile guests.”

“Oh.”

“We’re only interested in mobile consumers.”

“Totally.”

“These engagement photos are really lovely.”

“Thanks.”

“You make a very beautiful couple.”

“Awesome.”

“Let’s talk about finances.”

I feel a pump of excitement. “Well, between the photo booth, the fireworks, the dancers, and all of the complimentary taxis, to cover the reception alone we’re going to need—”

“The finances of the guests.”

“Er.”

“Average income?”

“Uh, ninety-six thousand and fifty.”

Paige and Kayla lean in toward each other, murmur, then nod, and turn back to us with smiles.

“Sorry, fellas, just isn’t going to work for us.”

My heart sinks. Paige and Kayla stand. I run my hands through my hair and over my mouth in distress and then suddenly am begging, “Please, we had a different sponsor, a legitimate national headline sponsor, we did everything like we were supposed to, we applied over a year in advance, we had to turn down other offers, and then our sponsor went out of business and didn’t even tell us what was happening until this morning, and it would mean a lot to our friends and our families to hear that our wedding had been saved by a local company, you’re the only ones that can help us,” but Paige and Kayla are already walking out of the boardroom, leaving the fluorescent binder with the wedding paperwork behind.

Jenna sent me a selfie of her binge-eating a pint of gelato, asking how much luck we’re having. I send her back a sweaty-face smiley with a couple of thumbs-up emojis, saying that we’re still looking. We’re not. BJ’s® was our last chance. There’s nowhere else in town to try. I feel dizzy leaving the building. I stumble into a mailbox. I lean against a streetlight.

“Deep breaths,” Ty says.

“This is a nightmare,” I say.

Ty calls an emergency meeting at noon with the other groomsmen, Braden, Parker, and Alejandro. Braden and Parker are twins. Alejandro is an only child. When we were kids we built a fort out of used tires and scrap metal in Ty’s backyard, where we’d go when we were dealing with bickering parents or dying grandparents or just wanted to hang out. Braden went to school at Energizer® Tufts. Parker went to school at Zippo® Emerson. Alejandro never went to anywhere and works in construction like me. As charcoal briquettes

burn in the grill, we smoke a joint in neon lawn chairs in the dazzling sunshine on the stoop of Alejandro's house, which used to be sponsored by Budweiser®, fell into disrepair, plunged in valuation, and now is sponsored by Hellmann's Blue Ribbon Mayonnaise®.

"We tried literally every company in Boston," Ty says.

"I'm doomed," I say.

"You really are," Braden says.

"You totally failed," Parker says.

Ty reaches into the cooler and flings a handful of ice at Braden and Parker, who duck the cubes with a pair of grins. Across the street, kids in bright swimsuits run through sprinklers on the lawns of houses sponsored by Marlboro® and Drano® and Spam®. Rainbows fade in and out above the spraying water. Alejandro tears the plastic wrapper from a package of paper plates, delts bulging.

"It's not like the wedding is canceled," Braden says.

"There's still going to be a wedding," Parker says.

I explode, "You guys don't get it. It won't be the same. That sponsor was like half of the budget. That sponsor was backing all of the highlights. The rest of the sponsors are just for props. Fuck, this ceremony was her dream. You should've seen her face when she'd talk about it. The way she'd glow. I'm serious, this is going to break her heart. She doesn't deserve this, she's a good person, she's responsible, she's friendly, she never swears online, she never posts politics, she's nice to old people, she volunteers with cancer kids. And she isn't even like that to get sponsors. That's just who she is. She's perfect."

Braden and Parker get somber.

"The best a man can get," I murmur, trailing off.

A breeze drifts across the yard. The smell of freshly mowed grass. A couple of bottles clink together as melting ice cubes shift in the cooler, and then the street is quiet again

aside from the occasional squeal from the kids across the street. Alejandro squats on the stoop, lays Johnsonville® brats onto the grill with a sizzle, pops the caps on some bottles of Heinz® and French's®, sets a bag of Lay's® chips by the plates, and then suddenly freezes with an expression of shock.

"Guys. Brock," Alejandro exclaims. "I just figured out how to save the wedding." He turns to me with an excited look. "You just have to talk to Simon."

My mind flashes onto a pale, skeletal, frightened face: Simon, the goth kid from the neighborhood, who used to wear eyeliner and lipstick, was known to hold seances in the graveyard across from the dollar store, got ass-beatings with a pathetic regularity, and never had even a single friend.

Ty squints. "Simon from the block?"

"No way," I say.

"Dude somehow landed a job at Mattel," Alejandro says.

"I won't."

"He runs the advertising department for Barbie," Alejandro says.

"I can't."

"He's living in Washington now. I ran into him last month. He was back visiting his mom. I got his number and everything," Alejandro says.

"He'd *never* help me," I say.

"Are you kidding? After you grew up in the same neighborhood? The same block? How could he deny a bond like that?"

"Because he *hates* me," I say.

"What, cause of the incident with the zucchini?"

"Man, that wasn't your fault."

"Yeah, you can't be blamed for that."

“Seriously, he’s probably forgotten all about that by now.”

Alejandro is already dialing the number. He’s always been the runt of the group, jacked now but still the shortest. He loves any chance to act as spokesperson.

“Simon? Yo, what’s up. Alejandro, from the block. Listen, we’ve got a situation. Do you remember Brock?”

Ty grabs me by the arms and looks me in the eyes with a grin.

“Bro, seriously, just imagine the annual budget for the ad department at *Barbie*.”

Alejandro covers the mic on the phone.

“He wants us to drive down to talk about the deal in person,” Alejandro whispers.

Ty does a fist-pump, high-fives Braden and Parker.

I grimace.

“This is going to be a hell of a Hail Mary,” I say.

We hop into Alejandro’s jeep, swing through a Speedway® for some Cokes™ and a Pepsi™ (Ty always has to be different), and then road-trip down the coast with hip-hop thumping over the stereo. Seagulls soar above the expressway. Models shimmer on the billboards. The sky is crystal clear. We hit the District at sunset, gliding through downtown with windblown hair. Tourists are snapping photos of the Goldman Sachs® White House. Flags billow majestically at the base of the Washington Monument, presented by Viagra™. On the sidewalk, beggars in ragged clothing sit slumped over hats full of change. A rabid-looking hobo with bloodshot eyes and a natty beard stands at a corner, tinted fluorescent red by a stoplight, holding a battered cardboard sign scrawled with a slogan: “Masters Brand Their Slaves.”

The hobo bobs his head in rhythm with the music in the jeep.

“Turn that shit up!” the hobo shouts.

We laugh and cheer and then crank up the music, and for a moment an awesome, pure

hope pumps through me, that the wedding is actually going to be saved. Jenna sent me a selfie of her pouting in a bathtub, asking if we've found a sponsor yet. I send her back a bouquet of heart emojis, promising we'll have a new sponsor locked by midnight.

Dusk is falling as the jeep coasts into Simon's neighborhood, a block of urban palaces whose stoops are flanked by soaring pillars. We all go quiet. The stereo is off. Stars glimmer above his driveway as his gate swings apart to let the jeep pass. Water burbles from a tiled fountain. The willow trees are becoming silhouettes. His convertible is sponsored by Rolex® and Chanel®. His mansion is sponsored by Facebook® and Google®.

"Shit, man, he didn't tell me he was living like *this*," Alejandro says, glancing from the convertible to the mansion with a look of awe.

Ty rings the doorbell as we cluster around each other nervously on the porch.

Simon's wife is a cadaverous brunette with a foreign accent, hauling apart the doors wearing nothing but a cucumber mask and a silk kimono. She must have known we were coming, because she never asks who we are, just greets us and leads us past a grand carpeted staircase into a wallpapered hallway lit only by the moonlight streaming through the latticed windowpanes. Music like a meditation soundtrack plays over hidden speakers. A bamboo flute. Some tinkling chimes. On the walls hang monstrous landscape paintings, each caked so thick with oil that the surface has a visible texture. Between the windows stand figurative marble sculptures, each contorted into a posture so grotesque that the stones have palpable emotions. The rugs are as plush as sod. I feel out of place in a tank top and khaki shorts, flip-flops flapping on the floor.

She drops us at the doorway to a wood-paneled office where a Tiffany® lamp smolders next to an Apple® laptop glowing on a desk. Simon sits in a claw-footed chair, drinking wine from a crystal goblet, wearing an elegant black tunic over tapered black slacks. He cut the floppy ponytail that he always had when we were younger and now has wavy

moussed hair parted at the side, but aside from that and some crow's-feet wrinkles, he looks exactly the same as he looked as a kid, pale and gaunt with light gray eyes and a freakishly weak chin. Above the desk colorful video clips from his life stream across a screen in a golden frame. He graduated from both Microsoft® Harvard and Amazon® Princeton. He's gambled at Bellagio presented by Mastercard®, skied at Vail presented by Swarovski®, and glamped in the Best Buy® Grand Canyon, the ConocoPhillips® Smokies, and the ExxonMobil® Everglades. His wedding was sponsored by Disney®, with hot-air balloons, horse-drawn carriages, and complimentary stained-glass slippers presented by The Magic Kingdom™. Seeing images from his wedding, him and his wife exchanging vows under blooming wisteria in a grove of blinking fireflies, him and his wife feeding each other dollops of frosting from a towering gold-leaf cake, immediately makes me think of Jenna. She's counting on me. This has to work.

"Simon, bro, it's great to see you," says Ty, who always loves everybody, especially anybody from the block, and sounds genuinely excited. "What a place. I'm lovin' it. So you sponsor weddings at Barbie?"

"Sure, we do weddings," Simon says.

He's staring at me with an expression of loathing.

He hasn't forgotten the incident with the zucchini.

This isn't going to work.

"Brock here is getting married next month, like we mentioned," Alejandro says.

"Best man," Ty waves, grinning proudly.

"And out of nowhere, the headline sponsor just fell through," Alejandro says.

"Braden, Parker, please don't touch that, it's very expensive," Simon snaps without glancing away from me. Looking guilty, Braden and Parker set an ancient-looking ceremonial dagger back into a wooden stand on the bookcase.

Alejandro hesitates. “Anyway, we thought maybe you could help him out, you know, him being from the block and all.”

Simon nods with a neutral expression.

Tentatively, I hold out the fluorescent binder. “I’ve got the headshots, the guest list, the average income, all of that.”

“That won’t be necessary,” Simon says.

“Oh.” I lower the wedding paperwork, feeling confused.

Simon faintly smiles.

“Brock, do you remember that random pole in the sidewalk at the corner of the street?”

“Yeah?”

“I always wondered, why did each of you always slap the pole when you went by?”

I glance at the others.

“Um, just a tradition?” I say.

Simon folds his hands together in his lap.

“It makes me emotional seeing that all of you are still friends,” Simon murmurs.

He turns to gaze at the moon out the window, the light of the lamp shining across his moussed hair, with a faraway quality to his voice suddenly.

“I went back to the block earlier this summer,” Simon says. “Stayed with my mother for the weekend, showering in my old bathroom, sleeping in my childhood bed. It was strange being back. The way the neighborhood has changed. The cars. The houses. I didn’t even recognize most the people living there. My mother said something during the trip that stayed with me, though. That the most important thing in life is integrity. You have to stay true to who you are. You always have to honor where you come from. That’s what she said.”

I frown.

“Wait, so you’ll help me?” I say.

He blinks at the moon without turning from the window, his voice taking on a sudden eager intensity, the light of the lamp sparkling in his gray eyes.

“I always wanted to be friends with you,” Simon says. “All of you. I used to watch you, hanging out together, playing basketball at the park. I knew that none of you were like me, but still, I used to fantasize about us becoming friends somehow. Everything that I did alone, I’d imagine us doing together. Reading tarot in the bathroom at school. Making poppets from twigs and shoelaces. Drawing sigils on sidewalks and trees. Ouija in the graveyard. You were always the ones I pictured. You’ve always been special to me in that way.”

I squint.

“So, then you’ll help me?” I say.

Simon glances at me.

“I’ll help you,” Simon says, “if, and only if, you do a ritual with me, taking a vow swearing your eternal devotion to the devil.”

I’m speechless.

“Simon, that’s pretty fucked up,” Ty says, sounding genuinely scandalized.

Simon looks at him. “Wouldn’t you agree something ‘pretty fucked up’ once happened to me?”

“He means the incident with the zucchini,” Alejandro whispers.

“Brock, that *was* messed up,” Braden says.

“You *have* to admit, bro,” Parker says.

“I thought that wasn’t my fault?” I hiss.

“Anyway, devil worship is a perfectly valid religion,” Simon says, rising gracefully from the claw-footed chair.

"I'm not going to do any creepy rituals with you," I say.

"If you want a sponsor you're going to have to," Simon says.

I grimace.

Ty thinks, scowls, and then says, "Brock, it's *Barbie*."

Simon leads us through a carved wooden door, down rough cement steps, and into a wine cellar lined with racks of corked bottles sealed with wax. The air down there has a chill, but then at the end of the wine cellar he takes us through a locked door with no knob or handle, only a keyhole, and we're hit by a warm breeze. We step into a hot dark chamber the size of a locker room shower. Rippled black candles with charred wicks are arranged in a circle on the floor around a pentagram painted with white paint. On the far wall, a mildewed chest with rusted latches sits on a decrepit altar. Above the altar hangs a horned skull with gigantic eye sockets and nubby teeth. A skull from a goat. Otherwise the chamber is empty. No windows. No vents. No other doors. My neck and my arms are already slick with sweat from the heat. Simon lights the candles with a book of matches, looking delighted, and then motions for me to kneel in the pentagram. I don't want to kneel. I kneel. The floor feels rough under my knees. My nostrils flare at a musty smell. Ty and the others gather around the pentagram with nervous expressions. The scene reminds me of when we once took a shortcut as kids, strolling through the weedy ruins of an abandoned warehouse, where we suddenly stumbled onto a pair of teenagers in hoodies mugging somebody at gunpoint. That petrifying feeling of having wandered into someplace we shouldn't be.

I believe in three things in life: protein, weightlifting, and true love. I don't believe in gods and demons. I don't believe in hell and heaven. (Except for Jenna, my paradise here on Earth!) Still, my grandparents are all Catholic, and the pentagram freaks me out.

Simon stands beneath the goat skull at the altar.

“Repeat after me,” Simon says.

“You know this doesn’t mean anything, right?” I say.

“Brock, are you doing this or not?” Simon says.

“It’s just words,” I say.

Simon smiles.

The candles flicker as we do the ritual.

“I bow my head to the Prince of Darkness.”

“I bow my head to the Prince of Darkness.”

“I pledge my life to Lucifer.”

“I pledge my life to Lucifer.”

“I promise my soul to Satan.”

“I promise my soul to Satan.”

I don’t feel any different afterward. My heart is beating faster than after any workout ever. I’m still me though. And it’s done. It’s over now. That’s what I’m thinking, that the ritual is finished, when Simon turns to the altar to flip the latches on the ancient wooden chest. He lifts the lid. Mist pours out of the chest like fog from a freezer. Simon turns back toward the pentagram palming a dark red lump of flesh.

“What the hell is that?”

“The heart of a pig.”

Simon reaches across the pentagram to offer me the heart.

“Eat it,” Simon says.

“Fuck no,” I spit.

“Brock, the ritual isn’t complete until you do.”

Ty and the others are watching from the shadows. Braden looks stunned. Parker looks nauseous. Alejandro’s eyes have never been so wide. Ty nods, then whispers, “Just do it.”

Beneath my tank top, a bead of sweat dribbles down my spine, slipping past my tailbone, soaking into the waistband of my khaki shorts. I think about Jenna's face. The little dimples in her cheeks when she smiles. I hesitate, then turn back toward Simon. My glutes are tensed from kneeling. My jaw is clenched together hard. My hands are trembling suddenly, which makes me feel ashamed. I'm afraid. I take the heart, cupping the raw lump of flesh between my palms. The flesh is frosted but isn't frozen. Wax trickles from the candles as the flames flicker. Simon looks ecstatic. I part my lips, then bend down and bite into the heart like an apple, twisting my head to tear off a mouthful with my teeth. The meat is cold and spongy. Flavorless. Gritty with crystals of ice. Blood dribbles from my mouth to my chin, dripping onto the floor. I'm the strongest man she's ever known. Jenna told me that once, the night we got engaged. That's why she loves me. Strong in spirit, strong in body. Eating a heart isn't any different than doing squats or curls. Each bite is another rep. I chew. I swallow. I fight the urge to gag.

Later that summer, in a tuxedo, standing at the altar in the cathedral at the ceremony presented by Neanderthal Princess Barbie™ as hired musicians make the strings on violins and violas and cellos sing, and trained swans nestle in pairs near the Gerber® archway of dried roses, and rented butterflies flutter in clusters between the Pampers® vases of fresh orchids, and live actors silently reenact the most significant scenes of our courtship in the sunlight streaming into the church through the stained glass, and our guests dab at tears with complimentary silk handkerchiefs in the pews, and Jenna walks toward me down the aisle wearing her Allstate® veil and her Verizon® earrings and her glittering Home Depot® dress, I think to ask myself, was it all worth it?

And it was. Of course it was. It really was.

About The Author

Matthew Baker is the author of the graphic novel *The Sentence*, the story collections *Why Visit America* and *Hybrid Creatures*, and the children's novel *Key Of X*. Digital experiments include the temporal fiction "Ephemeral," the interlinked novel *Untold*, the randomized novel *Verses*, and the intentionally posthumous *Afterthought*.

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